Alex Siebenaler

Honors Reflection 2

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# Research, Scholarly, and Creative Activity IBE Reflection

When I joined the IBE, I thought this would be a cool experience for me to get my foot in the door in the College of Business as it is a very hands-on class and there is a lot of opportunities for people involved. It was my first real semester in the College of Business after switching majors from aviation, so this was a super critical semester for me. At the end of the day the IBE did way more than that for me and truly shaped the beginning of my journey here at MNSU. What is the IBE you may ask, well this stands for the Integrated Business Experience and this is an opportunity for you to essentially build a business from the ground up. In one semester you get assigned a random group of 15-20 students, do product research, pick a product or service to actually sell to the community, take out an actual loan from the bank, and then the last half of the semester is selling that product and trying to make an impact on the community. All proceeds end up going to a charity of your choice. Something that made this experience super cool for me was that I was the CEO of our company, COREMOTION, and was able to lead our group, as well as be a part of every stepof the process, whether it was marketing, finance, or operations.

I was able to learn so much from this experience that I cannot even fathom where to start. Not only did I learn on a deeper level about what running a business is about, but I also learned the importance of other aspects like being professional, networking, and working in a team. The research side of the project stood out to me the most, starting with the creative research we did at the beginning of the semester. It is super unique because in the IBE you want to do something new that hasn't been done before but will also sell. As a company we wanted our product and company to have a deeper meaning and not just sell stuff with our logo on it like most people end up doing. Our company was called COREMOTION and we ended up deciding to be a brand that is committed to promoting awareness to mental and physical health. This was unique because as a company we believed that these two things go hand and hand and can really boost someone's well-being. We also aligned well with a trauma foundation in Mankato called footnotes trauma foundation that focuses on people with huge traumatic issues like PTSD, assault, or any other things that could make a person struggle with day-to-day life things. They really have a focus on doing things to help get these people back on their feet like going to the gym again or eating meals again, which aligned closely with our mission.

Our product and supplier research was mostly about locating, evaluating, and organizing existing information. This was because so much help with this was already provided and done prior by other people. Some specific examples of this were that many companies had done clothing brands years prior. With this we had

access to their manufacturers as well as the companies they screen printed or embroidered through. Also, we had an advisor for our company who had done the IBE before and who had recommendations on things as well. We ended up doing our embroidery through one of these companies as well as using advice from another member of the community for our quarter zip supply. All of our other products, however, were more unique to the company so we had to find somewhere to outsource these on our own, which was fairly easy, it was more just comparing prices. Finding products that fit our mission while still being original was honestly very difficult. We wanted everything to be usable in both an active setting and a therapeutic or recovery setting, and it was hard enough to land on products, let alone get 16 people to agree on them. Young Professionals (YPs) came in to give us ideas and feedback, which gave us a perspective outside of our group and was one of the things that helped us finally decide what to sell. I am still in contact with one of those YPs and was able to build a meaningful relationship from it. I feel like the aspect of helping the younger generation like this and being a mentor for someone will carry with me in my personal and professional fields after school as well. I thought it was so helpful to have someone who has been through college that wasn't family or friend to give advice and be someone to look up to. I also had an internship and worked with his wife too which was a fun experience I had as well building meaningful relationships. About a week before our loan presentation, we landed on four products: an activewear quarter zip, which gave us a clothing item and helped with marketing;

a journal that could be used for reflection or for tracking workouts; a massage roller for stress relief or post-workout recovery; and a shaker bottle for supplements that promote a healthy lifestyle. We also ordered bracelets to give away for free to anyone who bought something or followed us on social media, as a way to market the brand.

For suppliers, we started by looking at the ones previous IBE companies had used, including KT Bees as well as other local people which gave us a helpful starting point. We still had to use our own resources and compare options, though. Some members of our company had parents who owned printing companies, so we worked with them and got recommendations for other companies as well. After comparing prices and timelines, we ended up ordering from four different suppliers. This taught me how important knowing people is in business, since connections through past IBE companies, YPs, family members, and supplier recommendations gave us information and opportunities we would not have had on our own. It also taught me that supplier research has to go beyond price and quality. One conflict that we had was when we ordered our bracelets they came from China. We did not even think about a Chinese holiday delaying our bracelet order, and that showed me that location, holidays, production schedules, and shipping all affect when you actually receive something. This made us be more critical about fully understanding what we are ordering and our suppliers. Because we finalized our products so close to the loan presentation and ran into these

delays, our products arrived later than most other companies', which left us less time to sell.

Our market research was where we collected and analyzed our own original data. We created a lot of Google Forms and distributed them through our social media, to our families, and to other students, and we even asked our families to pass them along to their friends and other people they knew. In total, we received around 400–500 responses across all of our surveys. We organized all this information we got, mostly through google forms or from Qualtrics surveys, on spreadsheets. Bothof these platforms are nice because they display information for you easily, showing graphics and numbers. After we had some information on spreadsheets as well, we could organize it to see what was important to us, for us it ended up being heavily on demographic of age. We were able to cross work between our finance team and our operations team mainly to use this data to help with how much we needed to order and other details like that. Our questions would help get us some of that information. We asked people whether they would rather buy our products in person or online, what they thought was a reasonable price for each product, their age, where they were located, and why they would buy the product, as well as numerous other questions. We assumed our customers would be college students, and all our marketing plans were built around that. Even so, we surveyed students because we wanted actual responses instead of assuming they would buy from us.

One survey that really stuck out to me was the one we used to figure out our target demographic. The results showed that our brand resonated much more with people 40 and older, so we had to completely reshape our marketing. Our original plan leaned on social media and TikTok, which fit our own age group, but we shifted toward marketing in places where that older audience spends time, such as gyms. This taught me the importance of a target market. Sometimes it is better to focus on one group of people and truly relate to them than to try to relate a little bit to everyone. Without this research, I think we would have run into a lot of issues selling, donated less, and not made an impact on the people who really needed it. Looking back, I think our surveys could have been stronger if we had asked whether people would realistically buy the product. Knowing what someone thinks is a fair price is helpful, but it does not tell you whether they will actually spend the money, and that question would have given us a clearer picture of real demand.

The loan presentation was a major checkpoint where we shared our project in a real setting and received feedback. We presented to actual loan officers and had to show our products, suppliers, research, and an estimated forecast. Our research had to be thorough enough to explain why our business could realistically operate and repay the loan, which pushed us to make sure our decisions were backed by evidence and not just by what we thought would work.

Selling our products was another form of feedback. We kept collecting data on who was buying from us throughout the semester, and our marketing became

an ongoing research process rather than something we planned once. What worked, we repeated, and what did not work, we changed. Through this process I also learned how to use Meta Ads. The biggest takeaway for me was realizing that research does not stop once a decision is made. Our original assumptions were not completely accurate, and it was the real feedback from surveys and sales that told us who to target.

We also faced ethical considerations at several stages of the project. Early on, we had to decide whether to sell something trendy that people would buy or choose products that fit the purpose of our company. We felt it was more important to make a difference for a smaller group of people than to raise money by selling cute or trendy products, and that guided our product decisions. The same idea carried into our marketing and sales, since our goal was to reach the people, our mission was meant to serve and to make the largest possible donation to Footnotes Trauma Foundation. When presenting to the loan officers, we also had a responsibility to give a realistic picture of our business, since we were asking a real bank to trust us with real money.

The biggest thing I can do now is apply what I learned about research to any other business I am part of and to my career. I did not realize the importance of real-world data before this experience. It gives you direct feedback from your audience, and in our case, we did not even know who our audience was until we collected it. I already own a business, and I have used the same research and surveying techniques to learn how to get clients, along with trial and error to see

what works. I have also translated what I learned about social media marketing and Meta Ads into marketing for my business. I am learning that getting real feedback before making a big advertising decision saves time and money because I can adjust based on what potential customers want.

This has made the RSC competency feel much more practical, because I am not only collecting and analyzing information for a class but using those skills to make real business decisions. Business is transactional, and if nothing is sold, there is no way to be successful, so I plan to keep growing the ways I use research and try new methods of gathering information that will help me succeed in the corporate world or wherever I end up after graduation.